

and expertise in health and fitness. The site requires you to register, which involves creating a personal profile. After this is done, it's time to log in. One of the best tools that the site offers is My Health Scan. This involves answering a questionnaire of more than 40 questions about your health and habits. On submitting the answers, you get a profile of your health and how you can improve it. The health scan has sections on exercise, nutrition, stress, cardiac risk factor, cancer risk, etc. For example, checking the exercise prescription will give you the present status of your exercise schedule and advice on how you can improve it.

Calorie meter is another useful tool that the site has. Based on parameters such as height, weight, etc, it calculates how many calories you need to burn in a day. After you answer a series of questions, it determines how many calories you actually burn. This helps you alter your fitness schedule accordingly.

E-consultations is another neat feature of the site. It has two sections, MediXperts and NetCliniq. MediXperts allow you to consult an expert doctor online, but this service is not free. NetCliniq lets you consult an online doctor free of cost who gives you answers to your health related queries. Some of the other tools provided by Apollolife are the 'Are you fatigued?' test, Waist Hip ratio, and tools to determine stress at work. Message boards and health chats let you discuss problems that you may come across with other visitors to the site.

What the doctor ordered

Ever wondered how fit you are? Or how much you spend on smoking or your level of nicotine



Drkoop.com: all you wanted to know about fitness

addiction? Drkoop (www.drkoop.com) has all the tools you need.

You can use the Exercise risk calculator in Drkoop to check out if you are really fit enough to exercise. This will help you determine if you need to see a doctor before starting on an exercise regimen, however mild it may be. Check out how vulnerable you are to heart disease, HIV, diabetes type II and asthma, using the risk assessment calculators.

Worried about your kid's habits? Drkoop has tools to examine if your child is susceptible to alcohol and marijuana addiction, or has suicidal tendencies. Sign up at the My Health section on this site to customise the site to your requirements.

On the fitness front, Drkoop has tools to calculate calories burned and waist to hip ratio. You can find out if your diet is perfect using tools such as carbohydrate, protein, fibre, and fat intake calculators. The section on general health has information on depression, cost of smoking, nicotine dependency, cholesterol reduction and sleep requirement calculators.

Nexercise

Asimba (www.asimba.com) is a health and fitness site that claims to be capable of serving you irrespective of your present fitness level. It has programmes that cover people at all levels of fitness—from couch potatoes to those training for the Olympics. One of the best tools it has is My Training & Nutrition Log, which helps you chart and maintain your fitness goals. However, you have to be a registered user to make use of the services that the site provides.

Before striking out on your fitness path, stop a moment and assess yourself with Asimba's calculator tools. They can tell you how you can charge your body before, during and after a work out, as well as find your maximum heart rate. Other similar tools include those for finding the body mass index, resting metabolic rate, and daily caloric requirements.

The best feature in Asimba is that it lets you sign up for free training programmes for various sports and fitness activities. These programmes range from the relatively basic walking and running to those at the other end of the spectrum such as adventure racing (biking, cross-country running, etc) and triathlons. These programmes are of varied duration—from two weeks to eight weeks or even more. Asimba's fitness trainers send you each day's schedule on the day before the workout or on the day, as you specify. In addition to these free services, Asimba also has programmes that you have to pay for. These are highly specialised programmes that most of us won't be requiring anyway.

After choosing a workout plan tailored to your health profile, you have to keep a tab on whether you are working out right. Fitnessonline (www.fitnessonline.com) is the answer. It has lots of information for both sexes on working out correctly. The usual tools are there too—tools to calculate body mass index, ideal weight and calories burned. There are sections that cater to mental and physical health, adventure sports, and a guide for buying health equipment. However, it's the information on working out that is best presented. Information available includes getting in

Look Before you Leap

Hold on for a moment before plunging into your new fitness regime. There are some essentials you need to be aware of.

First of all, know your present state of health. Not everyone can jump into an exercise routine and go all out. To find out your present fitness level, it's not enough to use the online health scans offered by most health sites. If you are over 35, a complete physical examination is also recommended. This helps you select the right fitness plan and helps you maintain an online medical record. This record will also help the site tailor a fitness routine to your specific needs.

The next thing to be aware of is the cost of the fitness programme you choose. While most are free, there are some programmes that require you to pay up. Before you give your credit card number, make sure that the transaction will be secure. Most secure sites have a small lock icon at the bottom right-hand corner, or certifications like VeriSign.

Many of the sites offer diet planning tools that have been designed keeping the Western diet in mind. So if you find your *rotis* and *parathas* missing, don't worry. Most planners have food databases from which you can add the missing foods. In case you are unable to find a particular food in the database, they also provide for addition of new items. You can add the food that you want into the database. In this case, you will have to give the nutrient details of the food.